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THIS IS BAT COUNTRY

Volume I: The Sunrise Never Slept In

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Chapter One

Three Simple Steps

The shopping mall was dead. Caleb felt a kinship.

It stood there like a tombstone to prosperity — back when people had money to waste on mall-brand luxuries and the blind optimism to believe Dippin' Dots were the ice cream of the future.

The parking lot wasn't any livelier. Cracked asphalt. Flickering sodium lights. Empty spaces stretching into the dark. The kind of place where a scream could echo for a mile and not earn so much as a glance.

Dying mall parking lots are surprisingly conducive to grisly knife murder.

That's the thing with crime scenes — location, location, location.

He'd been on the case for a month now — ever since the first murder, when he recognised the M.O. So he watched. Waited. Narrowed down where the killer was likely to strike next.

It all led him here.

After all, Caleb knew how a killer thinks.

He rolled his shoulders and adjusted the sleeves of his denim jacket — old, faded, frayed. He checked his syringe of ketamine in his jacket pocket. Sterile and ready.

The plan was simple: find the guy, sneak up on him, jab the neck, end it quick. No fuss.

It went to hell immediately.

Caleb had wedged himself under what he thought was a dead parking-lot streetlamp — until the halogen snapped awake like God hitting a light switch to personally screw him over. Sickly yellow flooded over him. His cover was blown.

For one long, stupid heartbeat, they just stared — the killer in blood-splattered dad drag, khakis and a red polo; Caleb in thrift-store couture — both realising things were about to get ugly.

The killer was faster and stronger than he looked. The suburban camouflage hid something sharp, practised, and wrong.

Still, Caleb had one advantage.

He was *dead*.

When Discount Dexter threw a punch, Caleb caught it mid-air, bared his fangs, *hissed*, then slammed him into his faded red minivan.

"Yeah." Caleb let his frustration show. "*Vampire.* Didn't want to bury the lead. Stay still and this'll be over quickly."

It wasn't over quickly.

Because the murderer did exactly what Caleb should have expected when confronted with proof positive of the supernatural in the form of a nightmare bloodsucking creature.

He *screamed*.

Straight into Caleb's face.

And the scream stopped Caleb dead. Not out of fear. Not out of pity. Disgust.

Garlic breath.

Caleb doubled over, coughing.

"Seriously?" he wheezed.

His own personal kryptonite. His vampire strength left his body, his brain started skipping grooves, and the *smell!* Dear god! Like a dead fish left in Satan's humidifier.

The killer popped him across the jaw. Normally Caleb would shrug it off, but with lungs full of garlic, he reeled. The syringe he had prepared flew out of his pocket, skittered across the asphalt.

The blood-soaked man ran for the van's driver's seat.

Caleb was going to lose him… because the bastard had weaponised Olive Garden.

As the murderer fumbled with the ignition, flooding the engine, Caleb realised he didn't have long. He looked around for his syringe among the broken glass and rainbow-slick oil on the ground.

And then he heard it.

A faint *moan of pain* came from inside the van.

Caleb froze.

The killer's victim was *still alive.*

Caleb pushed through the garlic pain and rounded to the rear. The doors weren't locked, and he flung them open.

A young woman lay crumpled inside, barely conscious. Matted raven-black hair. A face carved in angles, like she'd been sketched in quick strokes by an artist who liked straight lines more than curves. Even half-dead and drenched in her own blood, there was something sharp in her profile. A kind of instinctive alertness, even in unconsciousness.

She wore jeans, a faded Alice Cooper T-shirt, mismatched socks, and most of her own blood.

The smell was sharp and metallic—familiar, of course—beneath the faint, homey haze of fabric softener and cheap shampoo.

She needed a miracle.

She got a monster.

Caleb scooped her up—fast, but careful. He was used to blood. Just not like this.

"Stay with me," he said. "Stay with me!"

He listened to the rattle in her lungs, saw the breaths getting shorter, weaker. Then, with a sigh that sounded too tired for his age:

"Oh, you are absolutely *not* staying with me, are you? I gave you one simple instruction…"

With her last dying strength, the woman in Caleb's arms reached up, extended her arm, and showed him her middle finger. She collapsed, unconscious, eyes open.

So there he was: standing in a dead department store parking lot, a dying girl in his arms, a killer escaping in a van.

Not the best start to a Sunday.

The van sputtered, then roared to life. Caleb had no time left to think. He had to decide what he was going to do. *Now.*

There was a version of this where he walked away.

And there was the other, *desperate* play. A line he *swore* he would *never* cross. And once he did… he could no longer tell himself that he wasn't *truly* a monster.

But he *needed* answers.

He needed answers more than he needed a clear conscience.

"Oh, Angelina's gonna kill me," he muttered. "And if she doesn't? She probably *should*."

He tried to hold onto that thought. If he held onto that thought, maybe he wouldn't go through with it.

He didn't know if he could live with what he was about to do.

But he knew he couldn't live without *knowing why.*

He lowered his mouth to the girl's neck, fangs sliding in. What remained of her blood trickled into him, heartbeat hammering—then slowing.

He pulled back, bit into his own wrist. Dark blood welled up.

He pressed it to her lips. Reflex took over. She swallowed.

Making a vampire isn't rocket science. Just three simple steps.

Step 1: Drain the victim dry.

Step 2: Give a little back.

Step 3: Learn to live with yourself afterwards.

Caleb had never really gotten the hang of step three.

The girl's head lolled, upside down. The last thing she saw before death was the van's license plate and its red tail lights vanishing into the night.

That was the moment that Caleb stopped pretending that this would end well.

As for the killer?

After he saw Caleb doing *something* with the woman he had just stabbed in the rear view mirror, he burned rubber, screeching onto the highway access road wide eyed and panicked. He muttered to himself: "Vampires… *Vampires?*"

"They're *real?*"

***

Detective Peter Wilcox adjusted his tie. His badge was clipped, his shirt lined up with his belt buckle and trousers, his tie was a perfect Prince Albert knot, pants pressed, and he even had a haircut recently.

That was because he had a Grindr date that night. But the date stood him up. Catfished, possibly. By the restaurant. A fake profile, ChatGPT to flirt back to you, and when the twunk you were promised doesn't show, well… you arrived hungry, didn't you? It was just the kind of thing that happened nowadays.

He would have made a bigger deal of it, but dispatch called him and alerted him to a homicide.

By the time he got there, the crime scene had already been roped off. Beat cops and CSI were everywhere and it was flooded with portable lights. One of the techs handed him gloves, a mask, shoe coverings and a hair net — and showed a blood-stained Nevada driver's license inside an evidence bag. It read "Patricia Antsel."

He sighed. Poor girl.

Oh well. This was his night now.

Wilcox crouched over the body, looking it over with his high-powered tactical flashlight. Antsel lay there, dead.

A moment of silence for the deceased. Then he had a job to do. He took out his digital voice recorder.

"Victim is Patricia Antsel. Female. Twenty-four. Multiple stab wounds." He looked at the corpse's arms. "Defensive injuries on the arms and right hand. She fought. Good."

Wilcox could tell already… if her killer got away, it was going to *sting*.

So. No shortcuts. By the book. Don't give a defense attorney a single handhold.

He looked at the wound patterns, shifting position. Studying them.

"Clustered," he said into his recorder. "Same placement. Same depth… but… with hesitation?" He looked at the marks — then traced the air above the wounds, re-enacting, without touching the body. "Yeah. That's hesitation. It stops. Starts again. Same spot. Didn't drift."

He stood up. The body wasn't going anywhere but the morgue. The coroner could give him more information later. He focused his attention on the scene itself.

It was hard to make out, but he spotted it. Shoe scuff marks. Shoe prints going toward and away from the tire tracks. Not a clean grab-and-go.

That was *new.*

He gestured for the tech with the camera. "Photo. With flash." The tech laid down a couple of numbered tents and took the photos from multiple angles. But Wilcox had already moved on.

He nearly missed it. But there was a glint in a crack in the asphalt when his flashlight passed. He moved closer.

In the crack, a syringe. Needle cap still on. Filled with some sort of liquid.

He stopped. Didn't touch it. Just studied it. "Photo and bag that," he finally said, pointing at the syringe.

That was out of place. If this was the same killer as the other two, there was no evidence he drugged his victims before.

It puzzled him. "A second actor?" he muttered to himself. "An accomplice?"

He looked back to the scuff marks. "An interruption?"

He placed a hand on the tech's shoulder, stopping him. "It's standard, but at the morgue, first thing you do is get a blood draw on the victim. Find out if there's anything in her system. And run it to the lab immediately."

Wilcox continued looking around, making sure he didn't miss anything. Then, he called over the cadaver team, who zipped up Patricia Antsel, age twenty-four, into a body bag, then carted her away to the morgue.

Chapter Two

Drunk

The toe tag read *Patricia Antsel*, but everyone she knew called her “Pants.”

She woke to a harsh fluorescent glare. Cold gripped her body—trembling, wrong. Frozen, but not. Her thoughts were thick, sluggish, as if someone were knocking from the other side of her skull.

Did she fall asleep? Was she late for her training course? Wasn’t she supposed to meet Jane last night to go shopping? What exactly happened—?

And then she remembered *exactly* what happened.

She remembered being grabbed.

She remembered being pulled into a van.

She remembered the glint of the knife.

She remembered screaming.

She remembered being *stabbed to death.*

Her brain refused to accept it, like a file her mind wouldn’t let her open.

She sat up to the crinkling sound of a white plastic sheet which was covering her. Touched her chest, stomach, sides. But there were no wounds. Just bruises.

She turned her head. A table. Someone lying on it. No, not someone—a body. Lockers. A *morgue*.

Her skin felt… wrong, too tight, too thin. Like someone had left it in the dryer too long and it shrank. A faint chemical smell burned her nose; disinfectant, metal, cold.

Then she saw the tag on her foot.

Not her shoes. Not her jeans.

A *toe tag.*

Her breath hitched. A scream tore out.

"Good. You're awake."

The voice came from the hallway. It was low, casual — like waking up in a morgue was nothing special. She turned sharply toward it. Male. Early twenties. Ponytail. Denim jacket and second-hand chic. Purple cloth in one hand, backpack in the other.

Not the man who'd taken her.

Still, she cracked, "Stay away!"

He froze, then took a slow step back, hands raised in a placating gesture.

"Okay." A beat. "Want some scrubs?"

That was what the man was holding — purple nurse's scrubs.

She didn't answer. He left the scrubs on a nearby chair.

"Not Prada, but it's something." He glanced around. "Déjà vu," he muttered. "Think that was my slab too…"

The man turned his back, and Pants took the cue. She slid off the metal slab, and quickly threw the scrubs on. They were too big. But she wasn't naked anymore.

"Decent?" the man asked.

"Yeah, but… stay away," she demanded. She backed up, found herself a little woozy.

The man turned back to her.

"I'm not going to hurt you," he said. "Stay calm. You're probably feeling a little drunk."

"Drunk?"

She hadn't had any alcohol.

The man in denim reached into his backpack, and pulled out a blood transfusion bag, then placed it in her hands. She looked at it, confused.

"The hell is this?"

"A Capri-Sun," said the man, dryly. "Drink it. You'll feel better."

"What, you mean like a—"

"Yeah," he said.

Pants slowly backed away.

"What?" she said, confused.

"What?" she said, horrified.

"What!?" she said, outraged.

She sneered. "I remember you!" she said. "You were there!" She stepped towards him. Controlled. Focused.

"What the *fuck* did you *do*?"

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Detective Wilcox still hadn't changed out of his date clothes, so he found himself all dressed up and nowhere to go… but the morgue.

Morgue Howie was working the front desk when he came in, wispy thinning grey hair, chubby cheeks, and a Hawaiian shirt, drinking coffee from a mug labeled "Embalming Fluid." Howie loved Hawaiian shirts, because he thought they hid food stains well.

They didn't. But Morgue Howie *thought* they did.

"Detective," said Howie.

"Howie," said Wilcox. Familiar. Not friendly. Howie was a good guy, but Wilcox was pretty sure that Howie's friends all *also* called him "Morgue Howie." Possibly his closest relatives. Wilcox looked around.

"It's quiet," he observed.

"Dead quiet," said Howie, who then giggled to himself like a mad scientist minutes away from pulling a big metal switch. Wilcox shot him a look, and Howie straightened up.

"We take what laughs we can," he explained.

"I need Antsel, comma Patricia," said Wilcox.

Howie slid it across the desk. Already open. Howie was looking at it.

"You had that ready," Wilcox said.

"Yeah," said Howie, "but look…"

Howie looked around conspiratorially. "This is the third one this month."

Wilcox looked through the file, methodically parsing the information, careful not to smudge any of the notes or photographs.

"Third *reported*," Wilcox corrected.

Howie looked over Wilcox's shoulder.

"Think it's the same guy?" Howie asked, with morbid curiosity, and the social tact of a man who spent way too much time around dead bodies and not enough time around living ones.

"I don't like to guess," said Wilcox. "You start guessing and you start to care more about proving you're right than on getting at the truth. It's why I never liked *Columbo*. Guy never really considered that he could be wrong."

Howie raised an eyebrow. “We *see* the murderer in the beginning. We *watch* the murder happen. We *know* he’s right.”

“It’s a conceit of the format, sure,” said Wilcox. “But none of his cases would go anywhere if the killers just lawyered up.”

Howie snickered. Wilcox flipped a page. Then stopped.

“Christ,” he muttered.

“Something interesting?” asked Howie.

Wilcox sighed. He might as well use Howie as a sounding board for his thoughts. He pointed to the photograph.

“Yeah. I saw it was bad at the scene, but I didn’t count ‘em. Seventeen stab wounds.”

“Seventeen?” said Howie. “Well that clinches it. Obvious suicide, case closed.”

“*Jesus*, Howie,” Wilcox replied.

“Actually, something I noticed — other two women are similar victims. Similar ages, similar neighborhoods…”

“Similar isn’t identical, and seriously— I don’t want to draw any conclusions before all the evidence is in,” Wilcox said. He furrowed his brow, and frowned. He didn’t like what he was looking at.

And even Howie could tell it was something disturbing, even by the morbid standards of a morgue manager desensitized to death.

“What is it?” Howie asked.

Wilcox sighed. “Noticed it at the scene. These are clustered,” he said, pointing to the stab wounds in the photo. “And there’s hesitation marks.”

Howie blinked, not understanding.

“That’s not rage,” Wilcox explained. “That means the killer, whoever they were, *took their time.*”

Howie frowned. “So you *do* think it’s a serial.”

“I think we shouldn't say that word out loud before we're ready.” Wilcox got out his cellphone. “I’m calling my partner.”

“It’s the middle of the night,” Howie said. “Ritter’s gonna be grumpy.”

“He’d be more grumpy if I didn’t call him. He hates coincidences more than I do.”

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“This is a prank, right?” Pants asked, still holding the blood bag in her hand. “A viral thing? Like… influencers, and… fake… morgues?” She shook her head. “Is VampireTok, like, a *thing?*”

“It’s not,” the man said. “Do me a favour,” he said softly. “Just… sniff it. Humour me. Science experiment.”

She scoffed—but curiosity won. She tore the seal and lifted it to her nose.

WHAM.

The scent hit her like a punch — intoxicating, irresistible. Before she could stop herself, she was tearing into the bag, sucking it down, warmth flooding her, the world sharpening, focusing, *snapping* into place. She felt every subtle current of air, heard the hum of the vents shift pitch like a note bending.

Colour seeped back into her skin. Bruises faded. Strength surged.

A moment of confusion.

Rapidly followed by *sheer terror*.

She dropped the empty bag and backed up until she hit cold tile. Breath ragged, she locked eyes on Denim Dracula.

“Holy *shit*!”

“Yeah, good to the last drop. Feeling better?” said the man in the denim jacket. ”A bit calmer?”

…No, Pants realised. Not a man. *Not a man at all.*

"Holy—you *turned me into a vampire.*" Her voice cracked on the words, like she was trying to convince herself it wasn't real.

Because of course it wasn't real. Was it?

The man — the *vampire!* — with the long hair didn't answer right away. He checked the door and the hallway beyond it, then looked at his wristwatch. It was a cheap digital Timex on a plastic strap. Then, frowning, he turned back to Pants.

"Yeah. I did. That's *almost* not the important part. We're on a deadline. We have to move."

She looked at her hands. Pale. Shaking. Still hers, though. And to be fair, she always looked pale under fluorescent light.

She should have been terrified.

Instead, she was pissed. She took a step forward, towards the man, confronting him.

"Why?" she demanded.

"Can we unpack the existential dread later?" the vampire asked.

"*No,*" she said. "You don't get to skip that!"

"I'm not. I'm triaging. I don't want to get caught doing a felony. Stealing the blood's a misdemeanour. And the scrubs. Petty larceny. Under twelve hundred dollars, according to Nevada Revised Stat–"

The vampire stopped himself.

"Not important. Point is, you don't want to stick around for the autopsy."

Autopsy? It didn't quite sink in yet.

"Autopsy *bad*," said the denim vampire. He pointed at the door. "We *go*."

Finally, she realized the implication. And scowled.

"I'd hate that," she said.

"Yeah," said the vampire.

"We're *not* done."

Time to *move*.

"Right," said Pants. "Where's my phone?" She looked around at the labels, the toe tags, the drawer numbers, the evidence bins…

"By now," said the vampire, "in an evidence locker. Presumably. Bigger priorities, though." He pointed to his watch. "Sunrise is at 5:12 exactly, and sunlight is *bad.*"

An empty silence for a few seconds. Then, because she had to ask the obvious question:

"How bad is *bad?*"

"Charcoal briquette," said the vampire.

"Like… instantly?"

"No," said the vampire, with sardonic frustration. "There will be plenty of time for screaming. On fire."

***

In the morgue hallway, the vampire took point, then waved Pants forward like a traffic cop when the coast was clear.

Which Pants promptly ignored when she saw an unconscious security guard on the ground. She ran over to him.

"Patricia!" the vampire stage-whispered. She ignored it, and checked the guard's pulse.

"Pulse is steady," she said, out loud. "And he's still breathing."

She blinked, then placed two fingers to her own neck.

"Jesus," she said with horrified realization. "I'm not."

"It stops being weird," the vampire said. "Mostly."

She lifted the guard, touching the back of his head, checking for other injuries.

"There's no bruises," she said. "No impact marks. He didn't fall… someone lowered him." She turned back to the vampire, raising an eyebrow.

"Of course I did," said the vampire. "I'm not a monster."

She shot him an incredulous look.

"I'm not *that* kind of monster."

She shot him a confused look.

"Usually."

"He's out cold. What happened to him?" she finally asked.

"He'll be fine," the vampire said. "Just out for a while."

"Did you put him to sleep with your… vampire powers?" It sounded ridiculous even as it came out of her mouth.

The vampire opened up a compartment of his backpack, with vials and syringes. "If you consider ketamine to be a *vampire power*, then… *sure.*"

"Oh," she said. She didn't know how to feel about that. Obviously not great about the drugging. But…

He zipped up the bag. "You sound disappointed."

"It's just… don't know. Thought it was mind control for a hot second," she said.

She caught a flicker of what looked like anger… and regret. "I don't do mind control," the vampire said.

Now that she had a few more of her bearings, a thought tickled through her mind. "You called me Patricia," she said. "How do you know my name?"

"Read it off your toe-tag," the vampire said. As if it *wasn't* the creepiest thing to say *ever*.

"Jesus," she gasped.

The vampire headed over to her, grabbing her hand gently, looking into her eyes. Then, speaking softly:

"I get it. You have questions. But we're *not* doing that right now. Every moment we waste here raises the chances of getting caught, and above all, we can not get caught."

He looked down, took a breath.

"I *don't* want to play this card," he said, gently. "But I *am* a very scary vampire. You should be at least a *little* afraid."

He took a breath, then continued.

"So… in the *nicest* possible way… I'm now *threatening* you. Please. Come with me."

A pause.

Pants punched him in the face, then ran from him as fast as her legs could run — which was faster than she expected. She nearly clipped a gurney as she slammed through the swinging double doors. She didn't even register the two men at the front desk as she ran past them.

As for the vampire, he stood there, stunned, looking at the still swinging double doors.

"Why did I think that would work?" he said to himself.

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Wilcox didn't see who was running, only that he heard the sound of footsteps, and double-doors swinging wide from an impact. By the time he turned around to look at the source of the sound, he only caught a glimpse — a woman wearing purple scrubs.

"Who was that?" he asked Howie.

"Purple scrubs. A phlebotomist."

Wilcox raised an eyebrow.

"Phlebotomists draw blood."

"Oh," Wilcox said. A pause.

"Then what was she doing in the morgue?" he asked, and followed at a walking pace.

***

She didn't know what else to do or where to go, so she just followed the signs pointing to the emergency room.

If "I've been turned into a vampire" didn't qualify as an emergency, what *would*?

The ER was bustling with activity as she headed in, looking for someone, anyone who looked like an authority who could help her.

Like, for example, the nurse at the desk.

"I need he—"

Before she could finish the sentence, doors to the outside slammed open, and an ambulance team barrelled in.

With a gunshot victim.

A *bleeding* gunshot victim.

"Gunshot! Move, move, move!" said one paramedic, followed closely by another one telling the rushing doctors, "He coded once in the ambulance, we got him back!"

"How long down?" asked a doctor.

"Thirty seconds. Maybe forty. He needs a chest tube, like, yesterday!"

Pants couldn't look away. An overwhelming hunger hit her. The smell of blood permeated her senses. She inhaled like a stray dog finding a grill. Licked her lips.

There was no romance to it. No myth. She was consumed with a predatory instinct.

She heard muffled heartbeats all around her. Very aware of where they were.

So, she forced herself to keep her feet planted to the spot. If she moved… she wasn't quite sure she could control what her body could do.

Finally, the gunshot victim was wheeled away. The feeling subsided… but didn't *completely* go away.

"Yeah, it's always like that here."

Pants took a while to realise the nurse she had approached was talking to her.

"Now, what can I help you with?" the nurse asked.

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Pants practically ran out of the ER, half-dazed, half-panicked. The sound of muffled heartbeats got smaller as she got further away from the entrance.

She looked behind her, and then took a couple of steps.

Then she immediately winced in pain. She had stepped on something with her bare foot. Shit.

She hopped over to a nearby bench, and sat down. She looked at the wound — broken glass, as she suspected. But it wasn't bleeding.

This night just kept getting weirder.

She looked back at the ER, and shivered, thinking about that hungry feeling. Dismissed going back as too dangerous. But… she couldn't walk away. Literally.

"Patricia?" said a voice from behind her.

It was the vampire.

"I wanted to apologise," he said. "The threat thing? Dick move."

He sat down next to her, slowly. She eyed him, warily.

Then she slapped him across the face. *Hard*.

The vampire raised an eyebrow and rubbed his cheek. "Ow! Seriously?"

Pants frowned in guilt. "I panicked."

The vampire nodded. "It's okay. I deserved that." He pointed to her injured foot. "I can help with that. If you want."

She hesitated. God forbid this guy was a vampire *and* a foot freak. "Don't do anything… wrong," she said, finally trusting him with her injured foot.

"I do a lot of things wrong," he said. "But I try to keep it to a minimum."

He pulled the glass out before she could brace. Pants hissed in pain, but the wound immediately healed up. Like Wolverine. Pants just stared at where the injury used to be.

"Well, not that I'm not thankful, but I'm pretty sure wounds don't work like that." She rubbed her foot.

The denim vampire looked around in furtive glances. "Look, uh, if the cops come by, I might have to bolt suddenly, but… well, let's stay here a bit. You seem like you could use a breather — figuratively."

She really *did* need a moment. She put her head in her hands. It was too much, too quickly.

"Vampires," she muttered. "I'm not bleeding. My heart's not beating... So. Cool. I'm going crazy."

"You're not crazy," said the vampire. "If anyone's crazy here, it's me."

Pants looked up at the vampire, and then, slowly, scooted away an inch or two.

"Okay… yeah, that was not nearly as reassuring as I meant it to be," he explained. "I probably need therapy, is all I'm saying. But good luck finding a shrink that works nights."

"This can't be real," she said.

"Patricia," the vampire said, softly. Kindly. "Look at me."

She did.

And he tweaked her nose.

"Honk," he said.

What the flying—

"Real enough?" asked the vampire.

Pants's mind glitched. The nose-tweak shocked her. The weirdness had completely disarmed her. The fear wasn't gone, but for the moment, it short-circuited.

"That… made it more surreal," she said.

"Just roll with it," the vampire suggested. "I need a moment myself. My plans are shot. I spent over a month trying to track down your killer but… he got away."

The vampire sighed, heavy, tired.

"A *month,*" he said. "Three victims."

"Three people you let die?"

"No," said the vampire. "Three people I couldn't *save.* What's worse... I think it's part of something bigger."

"Oh," she said.

They sat in silence for a few seconds.

"Who the hell are you?" she finally asked.

"I'm Caleb," the vampire said. "Caleb Tryst."

Caleb offered a handshake. Pants didn't take it. Instead, she stared at him in disbelief.

"Caleb Tryst," she said.

Despite her fear — no, *because* of it — she snorted. The stupidity of the name was a lifeline. Anything that wasn't terror.

"Caleb *Tryst?*"

"Yes…" Caleb said.

"As in… an illicit sexual liaison?" she asked.

"...yes?" admitted Caleb.

"That's… wow. That's a hell of a name. That's like—oh my god—that's like a vampire's *drag* name."

"Shut up," Caleb muttered, rolling his eyes.

She had definitely hit a nerve.

"No, I'm not letting this go. *Caleb Tryst?* Why not Amir Amore? Nox Turnal? Zayn Zexy? *Senna Guinne?*"

He closed his eyes and sighed — the sigh of someone who's explained this too many times, and hated it every single time.

"I had to come up with a new name, okay? The old me was legally dead. I thought, if I'm going to be a vampire, I'm going to be a *cool* vampire."

"'Caleb Tryst' is not cool," Pants said.

"I admit, 'Senna Guinne' is actually better," said Caleb. He shrugged. "I was going through a phase. Turns out phases last longer than you expect when you're undead."

"That's so emo it *almost* loops around again to deep," Pants admitted. "Almost." She sighed. "Do we have time for questions *now?*"

"One or two," said Caleb.

Pants looked back at the E.R.

"How do you keep—" She paused. "—*it*… under control?"

Caleb reached into his backpack and handed another blood transfusion bag to her. She stared at it for a little while.

"They really are a little bit like big Capri-Suns, aren't they?" she finally admitted.

Chapter Three

Exposition For The Recently Deceased

Hospital staff wheeled the unconscious guard past on a gurney, as Wilcox and Morgue Howie stared in silence through the doorway at the morgue. Discarded plastic sheet, empty blood bag, and toe tag—yet no Antsel, comma, Patricia.

They looked at each other. Neither saying a word.

Wilcox dialed his partner on his phone.

"Hello?" said a groggy voice on the other end. "Wilcox? What time is it?"

"Sorry to wake you," Wilcox said. "I think you should come down to the morgue at UNLV Medical."

A long sigh from the other end. The shuffling of clothing. Ritter was putting on his slacks. "Did you find anything?" he asked.

"Find something?" Wilcox looked at the empty morgue.

"No. In fact… the opposite."

***

Pants, in the cheap hospital sandals they give to shoeless arrivals, followed Caleb through the hospital parking lot.

He stopped, turned, and looked back at the hospital. Pants froze.

"Son of a bitch," he muttered.

"What?"

"The security footage," Caleb said, as if it explained anything.

"What security footage?" asked Pants.

"The morgue security footage. I meant to wipe it. I had a *plan* to wipe it. But when you ran… it got lost in the mix. Dammit. Wilcox is probably looking through it right now."

"Who's Wilcox?"

"Detective. Homicide. He and his partner are bad news."

She stared at him.

"We have… history," was all Caleb offered as an explanation.

Pants looked back at the hospital, thinking.

"Is there a way to wipe the footage remotely?"

Caleb raised an eyebrow. "No," he said. Then he thought for a moment. "Unless you know of a way to do that…"

"No," said Pants. "How bad is that? On a scale of one to ten."

"Eh, about a five," said Caleb, a bit too casually. "I'll deal with it later."

His eyes flicked back toward the hospital again.

From the look on his face, Pants suspected the problem ranked closer to a nine-point-eight, and Caleb knew it.

Caleb headed over to a battered grey 1998 Toyota Camry. Mismatched tires. Dents, dings, paint scratches. Neglect. Four wheels of disaster.

It looked more undead than the vampire did.

Caleb opened the passenger side door. Then stopped. Thought. Turned to Pants.

"Right, uh, is there anything I can do or say that'll…"

"...get me to go somewhere I don't know, with a strange man I just met?" Pants finished Caleb's sentence for him. "No. Especially not in *that* car." She pointed to it. "It looks haunted."

She looked in the windows. Exposed wires. Screwdriver in the ignition.

"It looks *stolen.*"

"Yeah, and the A/C's busted too," added Caleb. He leaned against the trunk and sighed.

"You *really* didn't think this whole making a vampire thing through, did you?"

"No," Caleb admitted. "No, I did not."

"So," Pants asked. "Who are you, anyway?"

Caleb tilted his head. "Do you really want the lore dump now? Can't we wait until we're somewhere less *exposed* for the exposition?"

"No," said Pants. "I have absolutely no reason to trust you. I want answers."

"I mean, you have a point," he said. "You don't want to get kidnapped and murdered *twice* in one night."

She glared.

"Too soon?"

She glared *harder.*

"Patricia?"

Pants grunted in frustration. "Can you not call me that?"

"What? 'Patricia?'"

"Yeah," she said. "It's a stupid name. Only my grandmother uses it—and we do not get along."

"Okay," said Caleb. "What should I call you?"

"My friends call me 'Pants.'"

Caleb blinked. He shook his head.

"It was from my high school e-mail address," she explained. "P-dot-Antsel became Pantsel became Pants."

"And you were just on my case about *my* name," said Caleb Tryst.

"Deservedly," she shot back. "And what's with the Canadian tuxedo?"

Caleb looked down at his denim jacket, then looked away annoyed by the question.

"Right, well… it's… sentimental."

"Sentimental?"

"It's the only thing I had from… *before*," he explained.

Pants realized she might have hit on something sensitive. "Oh. Sorry."

"That," Caleb said, "and a Blockbuster card with my livename on it."

Pants tilted her head. She couldn't have heard that right.

"Blockbuster? Jesus. Exactly when was your…" She struggled for the words. "...embrace into darkness?"

"Pardon?"

"Your… dark baptism," she tried. "When you got your… long night's gift…"

Caleb just stared at her.

"Envampification?" she desperately attempted.

"Ah," said Caleb. "Nineteen ninety-eight."

Pants, frustrated by the absurdity, shook her head. "Great. Well… that explains the *Lost Boys* cosplay."

"Classic film. Horrible ending."

"I vaguely remember flipping you off as I was dying," said Pants. "Good to know that you fully deserved it."

"You did, actually," said Caleb, who actually dared to smile. "I thought it was a badass way to go out. Like something from a movie."

Caleb caught her smirking. She didn't mean to smirk, and she certainly didn't mean to let Caleb catch her smirking. But she smirked all the same.

Then Caleb's face fell — and she heard sirens. Flashing blue lights followed. Multiple cop cars, sirens blaring, drove past where Caleb and Pants were talking, heading into the hospital. He looked at them with alarm.

"Are those here for me?" she asked.

"If they aren't, they will be when they realise your corpse is missing.I have to go," he said. "*Now*. I *want* you to come with me. You're my best lead to tracking down your killer. I'm your best shot at helping you get through this."

"Still don't trust you."

"I know," he said, exasperated. "But who do you trust more? Me… or the *cops?*"

***

Pants sat in the passenger seat of the car, staring out the window, as Caleb drove north on the I-15.

"Want the radio or something?" Caleb asked.

"I think I just need to sit," Pants said. "If that's alright."

Caleb nodded.

Suddenly, a deep THUMP-THUMP-THUMP sound emanated from the back of the car, which gave Pants a jolt of fear. Her mind raced to the worst case scenario.

"Oh my god, is there someone in the *trunk*?"

"*Shit*," said Caleb. "Not now!" He quickly pulled the car over. Pants noticed it sat slightly lopsided.

Caleb got out of the car and headed towards the back. Pants did as well. And then they both stared at it.

A flat rear tire.

The passing cars whooshed by. Headlights washed over them, their shadows stretching across the asphalt — long, skeletal.

Caleb glanced to the east, and then looked at his watch. He showed it to Pants. It read 2:24 am.

"Not great," said Caleb. "But we've still got time."

Pants let out a deep, sad, dark laugh.

"What is it?" Caleb asked.

"I'm actually a *fan*," Pants said. "Of the *genre.*"

"The genre…?"

"The vampire genre," said Pants. "Movies. TV. Novels. I used to write fanfic. Not proud of all of it. Okay. *Some* of it."

Caleb chuckled.

"Shut up," she said. "Point is, here you are. Vampire. With a *flat.*"

Caleb popped open the trunk, got out the donut.

"You're right, Pants," he said. "The movies don't do the glamorous vampire life justice."

Pants grabbed the scissor jack and the lug wrench, and propped up the car — this wasn't Pants's first flat either. When the jack sank slightly into the gravel, Pants stabilized it.

She handed Caleb the lug wrench, taking control of the donut, then looked at the flat tire. Like everything else on the car, the lug nuts were in bad shape, rusted.

"Need me to brace the—" she started to ask, but Caleb just tightened his grip, and with a loud CRACK, the first nut came loose. Judging from how quickly he was going through the rusted lug nuts, Caleb was stronger than he looked.

Caleb was stronger than *Schwarzenegger* looked.

"Oh," she said.

"Thanks for offering though," he said back.

Finally, with the lug nuts removed, and the flat stored in the back seat, Caleb motioned for Pants to hand him the donut.

"After the tire, what happens?" asked Pants. "You take me to the vampire king of Vegas or something?"

"Vampire king?" Caleb sounded confused.

"In the books, there's always politics. Kings, dukes, ancient sects in Italy or Romania or London…"

Caleb broke into a full throated laugh.

"What!? No… stop!" he said, grinning. "Vampires don't *do* that. No masquerade balls. No velvet thrones. No, Pants. It's just survival. Nobody has *time* for titles."

A police cruiser passed nearby, slowing. Caleb ducked down behind the car. Pants froze, until Caleb tugged at her sleeve. She followed his example and also ducked.

"What happens if they stop?" she asked.

"Best case?" Caleb said, taking a quick peek, "They think I kidnapped you."

"Worst case?"

"They notice you don't have a pulse."

The cruiser continued on in the night. Caleb looked relieved, then went back to the business of changing the tire.

"What about your sire," asked Pants. "The one who vamped *you?*"

Caleb, having finished putting on the donut, lowered the jack and put it and the lug wrench into the trunk.

"Don't know what happened to him. Don't know who he is."

Caleb's face dropped. He looked away for a second.

"It's kind of a sore spot," he finally added.

***

Ritter had been a detective for nearly thirty years now, and he *looked* it. Grizzled, unshaven, his suit jacket wrinkled like it slept in the car.

His nephew once pointed out that he kinda looked like the detective in one of his video games, which he took as a compliment, until he looked up what *Disco Elysium* was on the Internet. It didn't help that he worked closely with Wilcox, who made a point to be well dressed, well coiffed, and well mannered. It just heightened the contrast.

Wilcox was a good kid. Good head on his shoulders. And he balanced Ritter out.

After thirty years, Ritter knew when to trust his gut. But you can't take your gut to the D.A., and Wilcox focused on making sure all the pieces fit before jumping to conclusions. The young buck was better with the tech stuff, too—naturally.

He passed by a couple of uniformed officers talking to a CSU tech on his way to the security room, overhearing them talking about how they found "no oils, no ridges, nada" when they dusted for prints.

Wilcox and Howie, the morgue attendant, were over by the video bays. Ritter nodded to them both, then sipped from his cup of hospital coffee. It was strong, cheap, and bitter, optimized not for flavor, but to keep doctors awake and alert on thirty-six hour shifts.

He liked it, and made a mental note to ask them for their recipe.

"Tell Ritter what you found, Howie," said Wilcox.

"It's weird. We took a blood sample from the corpse—" said Howie.

"I mean, obviously, not a corpse," said Wilcox.

"Well, no, I guess in retrospect…" Howie shrugged. "Point is, Antsel's blood type came back as AB+. But according to her medical records, she should be O-."

"I sent the sample down to the lab for DNA testing," said Wilcox. "Could be the attacker's blood type — you know, contamination from the killer?"

"Attempted killer," corrected Howie.

"Or," said Wilcox. "It could be that the victim wasn't Patricia Antsel, only that she had Antsel's ID."

Ritter grunted. He was confused by all the references to "not a corpse" and "attempted killer." Was he not called down to the morgue in the middle of the night because of a homicide case?

He needed more sleep, more coffee, and more patience. He had the coffee. That would have to do.

"What am I looking at, Wilcox?" said Ritter, pointing to the monitors. "Help me out here."

"Right. Well, this is the security footage. All the tech here is obsolete enough to be a pain in the ass," said Wilcox. "Budget cuts. The video quality is potato."

Ritter snorted, unamused. "The quality is *what?*"

"...bad," Wilcox corrected, translating from Internet slang. "We're grabbing it, but it might not hold up in court. I was told that we would have to wait till morning, when the hospital's *one tech* wakes up, so that he can burn it to a DVD."

"Burn it to a—!" Ritter glared. "Wilcox. Promise me something."

"What's that?"

"If I ever have to get a major surgery?" Ritter took a deep swig of his coffee. "Drive me to *California*."

"Right. Well, I figured it wouldn't do to wait for the DVD. We should at least get some eyewitnesses *now*, otherwise some lawyer will say: 'How can you be sure the footage wasn't swapped out?' So we're bringing it up on the master system."

"I see," said Ritter. "Good call." He pointed to the monitors. "Roll it."

Wilcox hit the playback, as they watched the monitors.

"If you see something I miss, Wilcox, call it out," Ritter said. "I'm an old man. I shouldn't be up this late."

Wilcox looked at monitor #3, then sharply inhaled, jolting upright. His eyes locked on it, unable to believe what he was seeing.

"You're not the *only* one who's not supposed to be up, Ritter."

Ritter frowned, stepping closer to the washed-out security footage. It was grainy and desaturated. And on it, he saw a woman in hospital scrubs — the woman identified as Antsel — getting up *off the morgue slab* and heading into the hallway.

Most people would consider that the most interesting part of that video. But Ritter focused on someone else in it. He couldn't make out a face — it was never fully clear — but he recognized the build. And he recognized the damn *denim jacket.*

"Pause that!" he said, startling Howie. Wilcox did.

Ritter's breath caught despite himself. It couldn't be him. It *couldn't.*

"Ritter?" asked Wilcox, concerned.

Ritter rapped on the monitor with his knuckle.

"Put out an APB. Description only. Assume Denim Jacket is dangerous. I think the girl's a hostage."

"You recognize him?"

"*Maybe.* There's an old file I need to pull," he said. "If I'm wrong, it's nothing. But if I'm right…"

He scratched his head. Squinted.

"If I'm right… it's *impossible.*"

***

Caleb had taken Pants to an industrial park on the outskirts of North Vegas. Abandoned. Post-boom, pre-bulldozer.

It was quiet, all except for the insect noises and the wind dragging at dry grass.

Caleb parked the car. He got out, then came around to the passenger side to open Pants's door, then grabbed his backpack from the back seat.

"We're here," he said.

He headed over to the door, pulling out a single key from his pocket. No ring. No chain.

A life reduced to one lock.

"Pardon the mess," he said. "It's reflective of my mental state."

Pants stepped out. The weight of the night clung to her like fog. Red flags piled up. Don't get rides from strangers. Don't follow weirdos to deserted places.

But following the rules had gotten her killed once already.

Now she was… this. Vampire. Whatever. Her mind lagged behind her new reality.

Might as well see how this plays out, she thought. *But don't play it stupid.*

Pants scanned the empty lot. "This is a bad idea."

"What is?" Caleb asked.

"Following you. In there," she said, motioning to the building.

Caleb paused, considering that.

"Yeah. It would be, wouldn't it? Very 'don't go into the basement' energy."

"More like: Nuclear waste burial site. Do not approach," she said. "This is not a place of honor. Nothing of value is buried here."

"Harsh," said Caleb. "But fair." He looked at his watch. "On the other hand…"

He gestured towards the building like a game show model showing off a consolation prize. "*This* has no windows. That's ninety-nine percent of what you're looking for in vampire real estate."

Pants eyed it warily.

"Right, but you're a *vampire.*"

"As previously established, yes."

"If I go in there… what's stopping you from eating me?"

"Ah," said Caleb. "Already did."

"What?"

"The turning works like this: I drank your blood—well, what was left of it—then gave you some of mine."

"Oh, like in…"

"Exactly," he said. "One of the few things the books got right. Point is… I already ate you, Pants. Eating you again is like… vampire backwash."

"Oh," she said, processing. "Ew. So when you said that I might 'feel a little drunk' before, you meant…"

"Yeah. I drank you."

That one took a little bit more time to process. A question bubbled to her mind, and came out of her mouth before she could stop it.

"Was I… tasty?"

Instant regret.

"Oh wow," she said. "That is *not* something I *ever* needed to ask."

Caleb snickered. "Antsel Lite. Tastes Great. Less Filling. Sorry, that was dumb."

There was a sound like laughter — a dark, mocking kind that was almost a scream — coming from the desert. It took her a while for Pants to place it. A coyote howl.

"Oh, great. I get the full 'music of the children of the night' treatment," she said.

"Oh yeah," said Caleb. "The coyotes. They get louder near dawn."

Caleb finally turned the key. The lock clicked open, and the door creaked open on its hinges. He held the door open for Pants, not asking… just… *ready.*

"If it makes a difference," he said, after a moment, "I've got *Tetris.*"

"Tetris?"

"I read somewhere it helps with shock and trauma." He shrugged. "The not-screaming tipped me off to the shock part. Trauma's kind of a given."

She gave Caleb a look, then evaluated the open door. She stared at the empty lot, and the endless desert beyond it.

Another coyote howl. Then a second to answer the first. Louder than before.

The wind lifted dust across the asphalt. No one was coming. Nothing was waiting. Nothing followed them here.

She stepped inside.

Chapter Four

Dead, Dread, Diagram

Caleb flicked on a cold fluorescent light, then headed to a small mini-fridge. He loaded it up with transfusion bags from his backpack — stolen from the hospital, no doubt.

Pants looked around. His haven looked like a place grief built, time abandoned, and misery moved into rent-free. The kind of place where death didn't just hang around — it ran the homeowners' association.

Clothes strewn everywhere. A bare mattress with an army-surplus blanket that hadn't known warmth since Leo DiCaprio froze in 1997. Battered noir paperbacks—Chandler, Cain, Ellroy, Gran—in a small pile by the mattress. VHSes and DVDs nearby, mostly crime dramas.

The decor was half scavenged from dumpsters, and the other half... stolen from the houses of dead grandmothers while their grieving families were at the funeral.

An ancient couch which had seen better days sagged against the wall. Some of those better days included raccoons.

A DVD/VHS combo machine and an original Nintendo sat hooked to a CRT TV.

No windows, as Caleb promised.

And then she saw it.

The *murder wall*.

Pushpins, red string. Photos of women—victims. Notes on post-its in red sharpie. Newspaper clippings, most recent, but a few yellowed scraps from the 90s, and one nearly crumbling headline from the 70s. A torn map. A blurry polaroid. Red string, a web of obsession tied too tight.

"You have a *murder wall?*" she asked.

"Too cliché?"

"Too *serial-killer-adjacent,*" she said. "I guess you think you're… what? A vampire detective? That's what you do with eternity? Solve crimes?"

Caleb shrugged. "When I'm not committing them."

"I mean," she said, "I wasn't expecting 'Live, Laugh, Love,' decor, but I wasn't expecting—"

"Dead, Dread, Diagram?" said Caleb. "Fair."

He snapped his fingers. "Oh—right. One sec."

He wrote *Patricia "Pants" Antsel* on a Post-it, dated it, and stuck it under *Victims.*

"You couldn't have *waited* to do that?" she asked.

"Didn't want to forget."

Pants took in the room again. The sagging couch, the dead-grandmother décor, the bare mattress, the cold air of a place where nothing alive lingered for long.

No one could live like this, she thought.

And then it hit her—no one *did*.

This was a mausoleum with an 8-bit console.

“Look, uh, you can have the mattress. I'll take the couch. If you get hungry, there's bloodbags in the fridge. And some butcher scraps. Tomorrow... I don't know. Maybe get you some real clothes at a thrift store.”

“A thrift store?” she asked.

“Money's tight right now.” He stopped and thought. “No. Better idea. I should introduce you to Angelina. She could help. If she doesn’t decide to kill me first.”

“A friend?”

“More of an ex…”

Pants rolled her eyes, as Caleb sat down on the couch, thinking deeply while looking at the wall.

“Right,” she said. “Spill it.”

“I don’t get you,” she said. “Sometimes it feels like you have no idea what you're doing. And other times it's like you've planned everything. So which is it? I mean, what was the point in saving my life if you're not going to let me live it? Did you just want to preserve my witness testimony?”

Caleb didn’t answer. He just hung his head in an apparent admission of guilt.

She looked from the noir paperbacks and crime movies, and back to the murder wall…

…saw her own name pinned there like an exhibit…

…and that’s when the dread condensed. Hardened. Into something worse.

Comprehension.

“Oh,” she said. “You *did.*”

Caleb sank onto the couch, the weight of the guilt dragging him down. “You're the only one who can help me stop this, Pants. That's why I turned you.”

“How?”

“I’m hoping you remember something—anything. Some clue that leads me to him. Or there's... ways...”

“What ways?”

Caleb put his hand to his temple and rubbed it.

Good, thought Pants. *Why should I be the only one developing a stress headache?*

“I don’t know yet,” admitted Caleb. “There are people we could ask for help.”

“Who?” she asked. “The cops?”

“*Not* the cops. If people found out that vampires were real? Living among them? We’d be crucified,” he said. “Probably literally.”

Pants sat down at the far end of the couch. Distant. She sighed.

“Okay. Not the cops. Maybe one of my friends? When can I see them again?”

“You can’t,” he said. “You’ll get them killed.”

“What about my blackjack dealer training course?” she asked. “I already paid the six hundred dollars.”

Caleb shot her a look. Disbelieving. He shook his head.

“Your new vocation is ‘vampire.’ Hours are sunset to sunrise, and the pay sucks.” He took a moment. “Actually, is there anyone who’d come looking for you?”

“Come again?”

“Anyone who’s going to notice you’re gone? Family? Lover? Anyone you owe money to?”

Pants didn’t answer right away. She had *friends*, sure. Jane, for example. But… not like, ride-or-die-or-solve-your-murder friends. Her mother? Dead. Her grandmother who raised her? Estranged. Her father? Who knew?

“No… nobody like that.” It shook her. “Wow. I just realized no one is going to mourn me.”

A moment of silence.

“I’m sorry,” said Caleb. “But… that does make things safer.”

Pants frowned and sunk deeper into the couch.

“Anything else I should know?” she finally asked.

“I miss Italian food,” Caleb said.

The non-sequitur threw Pants.

“What?”

Caleb walked up to the murder wall. He had a sketch of the killer on it. Not *great*. But clearly *him*.

“I smelled garlic breath on your attacker. Reminded me of how much I miss Italian food.” He sighed. “No coffee, no alcohol, no food. Doesn't digest. Comes right back up. And it doesn't taste right.”

“What does it taste like?”

“Like the food your food eats. And I miss it.”

The fluorescent lights buzzed overhead.

“So…” she said, searching for the appropriate words. There weren’t any, which made the search for them all the more difficult.

“Sounds rough,” she finally concluded.

“It is,” he admitted. “I don't know what to tell you, Pants. I *do* realise that this started as a bad situation and I’ve made it worse for both of us, I’m not *oblivious*.”

Caleb looked at her, then looked away.

“I know how to keep us alive. The rest… I'm out of practice.”

There was the man behind the monster, thought Pants. *Count Chump. Dorkula. Nos-fuckup-u.*

"Okay," she said, begrudgingly. "For *now*, you get the benefit of the doubt. I'll go along with you. But I'm *not* your sidekick."

"Vampires don't have sidekicks," Caleb said. He paused. "You're thinking of Batman. I get it. Motif's similar."

"I mean it," said Pants. "I'm only sticking with you because you know more about being a vampire than I do… and I want to catch my killer."

Caleb nodded once. A long, uncomfortable pause. Nothing to say. Finally:

"If I could've saved your life," he said, "I would have."

"Duly noted," said Pants. "But woulda, coulda, shoulda."

He nodded, twisting his lips into a determined frown. Then, he picked up the video-game controller, and offered it to Pants.

"Tetris?"

Pants sighed, and took it.

"...fine."

Caleb headed over to the CRT TV and turned it on. It came to life with a ghostly whine and black-and-white static. He then headed to the Nintendo, popped out *Castlevania II: Simon's Quest*, and put *Tetris* in. He turned the console on.

The blocks were already falling. Pants just let herself play. And for a few brief moments, she let herself turn her fear, panic, and horror off. To let herself rest just a little bit.

Falling blocks. A moment of peace. Built one line at a time.

She didn't feel herself drifting off to sleep when the sun rose.

***

The morning sun had vanquished the horrible night.

Dawn crept over the Strip. While the vampires slept, Vegas kept moving.

And a man who had committed multiple homicides was buttoning his chef's whites at Canaletto Ristorante in the Venetian.

His name was Joshua Randolph. By day, he chopped vegetables. By night, he chopped bodies.

Only one of those jobs paid hourly.

Every nerve frayed. Every clatter made him flinch. Every voice at his back raised the hairs on his neck.

He tried to push through. Keep the mask on. Focus. Garlic to prep.

"Hey Joshua. You good?"

He jumped, dropped the knife. Darren, the line cook, was just collecting the chopped garlic.

"Hey, Darren. No, I, uh… didn't sleep."

"Again? Maybe you should talk to someone."

"I've tried," Joshua admitted. "But I can't."

"Embarassing?"

"No. I mean—I *can't* talk about it. I want to. I want to say—"

Joshua's voice seized. His tongue went dead. Nothing. He tried to force the words out, but all that he managed to do was a few guttural grunts.

"Yeah, Josh," Darren said. "So long as it's not booze…"

"It's not booze," Joshua said, regaining control of his mouth. "Or drugs."

"Girls?"

Joshua flinched.

"I'll take that as a yes. Weird. Thought you were gay."

"I am gay. *Extremely* gay," said Joshua.

"Then I got nothing. If you're messing with girls in Vegas, you're doing gay *wrong*."

Joshua looked down at the garlic.

"I'm doing a lot of things wrong, Darren. And I don't know how to stop." He muttered under his breath: "Maybe the vampire knows?"

"The *what*?" said Darren, who apparently heard that.

Joshua raised his eyebrows, and quickly forced a smile.

"The—uh—'Vampire Knows.' Saying. From Texas. Very niche."

Darren stared. Joshua's chuckle died fast. Finally Darren rolled his eyes.

"Just don't stab yourself," Darren said as he left. "We're short staffed."

Joshua barely heard him. His gaze had locked on the hotel staff unloading crates—onions, peppers, leeks. And *huge sacks of garlic*. He stared, unblinking.

***

After his shift, Joshua walked to the van in the Venetian garage, chef's whites stained with marinara and fryer grease. He slid into the driver's seat, setting a stolen sack of garlic beside him, carefully buckling it into the passenger seat.

He sat behind the wheel. Stared into the far distance. Then, tried to ground himself:

"So," he muttered, "I'm trying to catch a vampire now."

A long deep sigh.

"In addition to the murdering."

He turned to the sack of garlic.

"Unless you have a better idea?"

Joshua intellectually knew that the garlic wouldn't answer him. That if he heard anything, it would be just another voice in his head.

But even a hallucination meant he'd be a little less lonely. So Joshua waited a brief moment for the garlic to react.

It didn't, of course.

Joshua hung his head. Then he started the van and drove off as the sun set.

What a horrible night to have a curse.

***